

THE CHESTER AND THE OTHER ENGLISH SHEPHERDS' PLAYS

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If there were no Towneley *Second Shepherds' Play*, we would all be reading and teaching the Chester version. Indeed, each time that I have read the Chester *Shepherds*, I have been struck by how good a play it is, so perhaps we should be reading and teaching the Chester one along with the *Second Shepherds' Play*. I began to realize the theatrical quality of the Chester play when I saw a performance at Toronto in 1983. In that same production we also found out that the *rime couée* stanza was a good speaking verse and so the text reveals that it is not the primitive and awkward one it was once thought to be. And we also know that, as we have it, the Chester Cycle is not the oldest cycle but the latest.¹

At one time, in fact, I wondered whether the Chester playwright may have seen the Towneley *Shepherds' plays* or the Wakefield Master the Chester pageant. In their commentary Arthur Cawley and Martin Stevens note some similarities: 'The *First Shepherds' Play* comes perhaps closest in tone, temperament, and narrative detail to the play at Chester. Among the parallels, the most important are the First Shepherd's lament about his sheep's affliction with the rot (compare Chester 7:14, Towneley 12:38), the emphasis on real or imaginary feasting and drinking, and the occurrence in both plays of a character named Garcio in Towneley and Garcius in Chester'.² But I also think that, structurally and in social commentary, the Chester play resembles the *Second Shepherds' Play* without the Mak episode. It could have been possible for one of these playwrights to have seen the other's work since the Chester plays achieved their final shape c1500 at about the same time the Towneley manuscript was produced.³ Significant differences between the two may be attributable to venue. Chester's play was performed before an urban audience. Although we are unsure about the auspices of the Towneley *Shepherds' plays*, they may have been performed privately at Christmas entertainments at some noble's or wealthy gentry's house.⁴ I eventually decided that the connection could not be proved even though there are some intriguing likenesses not to be found in the other English *Shepherds' Plays*.

In this paper I wish to characterize the extant English Shepherds' Plays in order to show how playwrights responded to the biblical narrative, but specifically to note that the Chester and Towneley shepherds are presented more realistically than those in York, Coventry, and N.Town where they are represented as *pastores*. I will conclude with a discussion of the reception of the Chester *Shepherds*. Although the Visitation of the Shepherds was common in images and plays and presumably popular, not everyone thought so highly of them as one Puritan preacher's objections to the Chester *Shepherds* attest.

Since most of these plays were created for urban and town audiences by guildsmen or others, we would expect the dramatisations to represent their interests and piety in some way. But of what interest are shepherds to such audiences? How does one represent these characters? In the case of the city of Chester, for example, there was no tradition of sheep-herding in the area.⁵ Some of the plays — Coventry, York, N.Town, and the *Shrewsbury Fragments* — do not represent the shepherds naturalistically or as comic rustics but 'exegetically' as *pastores*.⁶

Because the biblical narrative is very brief, playwrights exercised considerable freedom in developing the story. After stating the circumstances of the swaddled Christ's birth in a manger (2:7), Luke 2:8–20 says that there were shepherds in the fields at night, an angel appeared to them and they were afraid. The angel tells them that that day in Bethlehem the Saviour was born and gives them a sign by which they will recognize the Child; then there is a chorus of angels singing *Gloria in altissimis Deo*. The shepherds make an immediate decision to go to Bethlehem. They report their experience to Mary, who ponders it in her heart, while everyone (the people to whom the shepherds report the event?) wonders at it. The shepherds joyfully return to their fields glorifying and praising God.⁷

The playwrights treated this narrative imaginatively, leaving out parts of Luke and adding material of their own:

1. in general the English Shepherds do not express fear of the Angel, though the Angel when it appears the second time in N.Town and Chester unaccountably asserts that they are afraid when that has not been shown earlier; rather, the Shepherds express fear of the cold and the dark and their nightmares. They usually express joy at the appearance of the star and the Angel;

2. omitted is most or all of Luke's verse 3 ('And the angel said to them, "Be not afraid; for behold I bring you good news of a great joy which will come to all the people; for to you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour who is Christ the Lord"') and verse 4 ("And this will be a sign for you: you will find a babe wrapped in swaddling cloths and lying in a manger");⁸
3. the angels' chorus is omitted except in Coventry;
4. some Shepherds hasten to Bethlehem while others dawdle;
5. the Shepherds do not report what the Angel told them ('And when they saw it [the manger] they made known the saying which had been told them concerning this child'). The verse may suggest they are speaking not just to Mary and Joseph but to 'all' who were there or heard it afterward ('and all who heard it wondered at what the shepherds told them');
6. missing is any reference to Mary keeping 'all these things, pondering them in her heart', which taken literally suggests she is unaware of the significance of the event or that she chooses not to discuss it.⁹

There are other features in the plays that are not in Luke: contemporary references to the weather, wives, and the political and social situation; the Shepherds' feast; the appearance of a star; the Shepherds' discussion of the Angel(s) song; the presence of the ox and the ass at the manger and their warming of the Child;¹⁰ spoken adoration by the Shepherds; the giving of gifts to the Child. Singing is important to these plays, but especially to Chester and Towneley. The importance of song, however, is not restricted to the revelatory one of the Angel(s); the Shepherds often sing their own songs out of a desire for companionship and consolation.

THE YORK, N.TOWN AND COVENTRY SHEPHERDS PLAYS

The York *Shepherds' Play* is the barest of all these plays.¹¹ From the beginning the Shepherds are treated as *pastores*, that is, they are 'shepherds' in an exegetical sense. After the First Shepherd complains that some things trouble his mind, he begins recalling the prophecies about the Christ Child and the star that had been written down by the 'witty lerned men of oure lay' (15:18). The reference to 'oure lay' constructs the Shepherds as Jews.¹² The dialogue continues with the prophecies followed by their significance. At the conclusion of this opening exchange, the Third Shepherd moves the play back to the concerns of their

occupation — the safety of their sheep — a move that initiates a more colloquial exchange of lines and half-lines as they express awe at the wondrous sight of the star. After hearing the Angel, the First Shepherd says he can repeat the song and they leave singing the *Gloria*. There is no commentary on the song; instead, there is a discussion of what the Angel's song means in prophetic terms. They move toward Bethlehem in order to see the Child, and readily find the house and the Child between the two beasts, as the Angel had told them they would.

At the presenting of the gifts, the First and Second Shepherds' speeches begin with the notion of Christ's power and conquest and His promise to save them. But their speeches end with requests for worldly advancement, perhaps recalling a similar request made by the sons of Zebedee who asked Christ to grant them positions in his glory (Mark: 10:35–41; Matt: 19:23–30, 20:20–24).

The First Shepherd says he is a 'symple knave,' though oddly he claims to have come from 'curtayse kynne'. He asks the Child that when He shall rule all not to forget him:

And whenne 3e shall welde all
 Gud sonne, forgete no3t me
 Yf any fordele falle. 105–7

The editor glosses *fordele* as 'advantage', which is accurate enough, but the *MED* cites instances of *ferdel* and *fordel* that mean 'a measure of land (varying in size); one-fourth of a virgate'. The Shepherd may be asking for position, but, given his status, he may also be specifically asking for land of his own. He seems to be saying, 'Don't forget me at the Last Judgment, but remember me if an advantageous situation arises in this world or if there is land to be given'. The Second Shepherd also asks for reward:

And whan 3e sall be lorde in lande
 Dose goode agayne, forgete me noght,
 For I haue herde declared
 Of connyng clerkis and clene,
 That bountith askis reward;
 Nowe watte 3e what I mene. 114–19

The last three lines may have an anti-clerical note, suggesting that clerics always seek advantage.

The Third Shepherd does not ask for any material benefits; rather, he prays that God grant them long living. Then he suggests they should go home again with mirth, perhaps an indication they leave singing.

The requests for material rewards — lands and status — by the first two Shepherds suggest that they do not have a clear understanding of the nature of Christ's regnancy, their misunderstanding possibly being a reflection of the worldly audience's. When they relate the prophecies at the beginning of the play, they seem to understand his blood will ransom them and so forth; however, the Third Shepherd only says that Christ will free the Children of Israel, a statement that is open to two different readings: to make them free men or to free them from Satan (29–32).¹³ The latter is suggested when he goes on to say that Christ will defeat the fiend. None of the other plays have these requests for worldly prominence or possession of material goods.

N.Town's *Shepherds' Play* opens with the Angel's *Gloria*.¹⁴ The Angel says that a child is born through whom many people will be 'vnbownde'; he will institute seven sacraments by means of Christ's wounds; and he is the 'flower of frencheþ' sent from God on high who will salve men's sins through 'Goddys sleytys slyȝ'. The Shepherds' initial responses focus on 'the gret lyght', not the song. The three, Maunfras, Boosras, and Moyse, immediately prophesy, but their prophecies extend beyond what the Angel says. They allude to Moses, Balaam, Amos, and Daniel. They conclude this with a rendition of the *Gloria* and then these 'unlettered' shepherds sing the *Stella celi extirpauit* as they go toward Bethlehem. There is no musicological examination of the Angel's song, only some attempts at what the words were. The *Gloria* is sung again and there is a brief discussion whether the song was 'Gle, glo, glory' (65), 'Gle, glo, glas, glum' (69) or just 'Glory' (70).¹⁵

Oddly, the Shepherds in this play are both learned (they recite the prophecies), unlearned (when they can't quite get the *Gloria* right), yet they subsequently recall more prophecies and leave singing a Latin antiphon. At Bethlehem they repeat the 'Hail' formula of greeting that is formalised by alliteration and that sounds like praise lyrics addressed to the Virgin or elevation prayers at the raising of the Host.¹⁶ The N.Town Joseph directs the shepherds to tell 'How God is born / Þis mery morn; / Þat is forlorn / Fyndyn he can' (123–6). There are no references to gifts. There is no political, social, or meteorological comment in the play.

The Coventry *Shearmen and Taylors' Play* is composed of a number of scenes that usually are treated separately in York and Chester. The play

opens with Isaiah as Prologue followed by the Annunciation, Joseph's Doubt, and the appearance of the Angel to him.¹⁷ The *Shepherds* episode, lines 192–313, switches between the Shepherds' *locus* and two Mary scenes at Bethlehem before the Shepherds appear. The Shepherds portion of the play opens with their complaints of the cold and the darkness of the night and of becoming afraid when buffeted by the wind. The Third Shepherd says that since it will soon be daylight they should sit and drink and eat until dawn. While they eat, they see the star; they wonder at it and begin to relate prophecies. The Angels sing the *Gloria*. The Shepherds are gladdened by the song and are able to repeat parts of it. Then the Shepherds sing, 'Ase I Owt Rodde,' which is a *chanson d'aventure* lyric about seeing the three shepherds and the angel.¹⁸ After a brief scene with Mary in which the Angels again sing the *Gloria*, they return to the Shepherds to calm their fears and to announce the birth of the Child (283).¹⁹ A second Angel tells them it is Christ's will that they see him lying in a crib of 'pore reypaste' (289) even though he is of David's line. The Shepherds approach and hail Mary and the Child and present their humble gifts. Mary says she will intercede with the Child to grant them blessing and they leave singing a third song — about the Angels — which is tied into the first by the refrain. The only naturalistic touch is the emphasis on the darkness of the night and the cold, but this turns out to anticipate Isaiah's prophecy, so it has a prophetic function as well (compare the opening of the Towneley *Second Shepherds' Play* where the Shepherds' complaints about the weather describe a fallen world). There is no social commentary in these opening speeches. At the appearance of the Angels, the Shepherds are transformed into *pastores* who prophesy. Their simplicity reappears when they go off to Bethlehem singing their lyric about the shepherds and when they offer poor gifts.

What these three versions have in common is:

1. the Shepherds are not particularly individualized (though at Bethlehem in York they self-distinguish themselves; in N.Town they have exotic names which would serve to historicise them and place them in the Middle East as Children of Israel);
2. the playwrights play on shepherds as *pastores*;
3. they are represented as simple and poor men (at least through their clothes and gifts);
4. none of their gifts has any symbolic significance.

By contrast, in Chester and Towneley:

1. the shepherds are individualised;
2. they have colloquial English names;
3. they are localized in England in various ways;
4. they are made objects of comedy (buffoonised);
5. there are four Shepherds rather than the traditional three and it is the fourth who watches the sheep (Chester, Towneley *Prima Pastorum*); Mak acts as a comical Fourth Shepherd in the Towneley *Second Shepherds' Play*.

THE CHESTER AND TOWNELEY SHEPHERDS' PLAYS

Prima Pastorum (Towneley Play 12)

The Shepherds are first represented as Englishmen who complain about transience, diseased sheep, unaffordable taxes (First Shepherd), and persons who prey on them (Second Shepherd). The Third Shepherd exposes their concerns about what are imaginary sheep and comically dumps his bag of grain to illustrate his point. Iak Garcio, who apparently is the actual keeper of the flocks, enters, ridicules the others, and abruptly leaves the scene — and the play. Excluding Jak from their feast, Gyb says 'we ... all thre' (276) should sit to eat and drink.²⁰ As in the *Second Shepherds Play*, they cast a garbled 'Latin' spell over themselves before they sleep.

When the Angel appears, the Shepherds awake in fear, but not at the Angel or his song: the First Shepherd thinks someone screamed aloud; but the Third, after thinking he heard a thunderclap, repeats part of the Angel's message; and the Second Shepherd seems to have understood the message, for he says they must seek the 'barne' signified by the star (458–64). They revert to *pastores*, quickly recollect Isaiah's and the Sybil's prophecies and other signs and prophecies. Hovering between *pastores* and Englishmen, the Second Shepherd complains of the First's *clergé*; he accuses Gyb of being a preaching friar. Unrepentant, Gyb continues with a translation of and commentary on Virgil's *Fourth Eclogue* (556–9) before they discuss the Angels' song and then sing their own (586–622).

The Angel-sequence moves from the Shepherds' incomplete perception of events to prophetic recollection (divine inspiration?) to transformation and marvel that shepherds rather than saints and prophets should be the first to see Christ (634–44).²¹ The Shepherds hail the Child and give

humble gifts for which Mary thanks them and they depart singing and testifying in 'lawde of this lam' (722).

The Towneley *Second Shepherds' Play* (Play 13)

The Wakefield Master's *Second Shepherds' Play* is the most audacious of all the plays on this subject both for its topicality and Mak's parodic 'Nativity'. All three Shepherds enter complaining about the weather before turning to the abuses they suffer: at the hands of his masters (Coll); at those of his wife (Gyb); and at those of his shepherd-masters (Daw). These references to the weather at first may have a naturalistic effect; it is cold, the shepherds have to endure rain and wind; their occupation is often very uncomfortable. However Daw, who is the most discerning of the three but the lesser among them, suggests that the weather is so much more extreme than usual that he concludes something of great significance is about to happen.

The oddity that the First Shepherd's speech has to do with ploughing has often been noted. Coll refers to himself and his companions as 'we sely husbandys' (14).²² Cawley and Stevens provide a contemporary context for the complaint (2 495), but I think the ploughing reference recalls labour after the Fall as well. The Second Shepherd's complaint about women might seem a commonplace, but Daw alludes to Adam's condition when he says 'Sich seruandys as I, / That swettys and swynkys, / Etys oure brede full dry' (221-3). The phrase 'swettys and swynkys' or the reverse is the common translation into English of Adam's punishment for having disobeyed God's commandment.²³ The allusions to the intemperate weather and wives' reversal of proper relationships between men and women recall conditions after the Fall: the weather changed; Adam became a tiller of the soil, usually illustrated by showing him with a spade; Eve was told that she was to be obedient thenceforth to her husband but the reverse has been the case; men and women are condemned to labour by the sweat of their brows. The whole hierarchical structure of society was established as a result, so there are some who labour but others who rule over them and take the fruits of their labour, one consequence of which is grouching, disobedience, and resistance among underlings.

The Mak episode continues the theme of the opening speeches. His 'Annunciation' is not one of hope but a complaint about the weather. He pretends to be a servant of a lord, Coll's proud swain come to borrow his wain and plough; and, like Gyb, has a terrible wife. Mak's solo is an

attempt to disguise the fact that he is a sheep-stealer, an occupation that has its own punishment, his marriage to Gill.

The Shepherds discover Mak's fraud only as a result of Daw's goodness (685), his natural impulse to give the sheep-child a gift. After tossing Mak in the blanket, they are weary and fall asleep. The Angel's *Gloria* (920–32) announces the miraculous birth but, unlike Luke, also explains its significance: He is born who will take from the fiend what Adam lost; God is their friend and they should go to Bethlehem to see that 'fre' one in a crib, 'poorely arayd,' between two beasts. There is a short repetition of the key elements in the Angel's statement (933–47), a musicological discussion of the song (946–58), and the decision to go to Bethlehem as directed. The Shepherds recall the prophecies of David and Isaiah that a virgin should conceive. They are not just joyful at the news of the birth but, like the Shepherds in the *Prima Pastorum*, because they are the first to see the child rather than the patriarchs and prophets who desired to do so. Up to the offering of the gifts, the Shepherds' speech has been very colloquial and informal, but now they move to a ritualised series of 'Hails'.

The *Second Shepherds' Play* alone has the Shepherds present gifts that may have some symbolic significance: a bob of cherries recalling the blood of Christ's sacrifice; a bird, His creation of souls; and a ball, an orb symbolizing his divine sovereignty.²⁴ Mary announces Him, says she will act as *mediatrix*, and directs them to 'Tell furth as ye go, / And myn on this morne' (1074–5). The Shepherds exit singing.

More dynamically than in the other plays, the overall movement of the Towneley *Second Shepherds' Play* is from helplessness and despair to hope and then to joy. The playwright establishes a correspondence between the effect of Christ's intervention in history (a unique event) and the effect of being transformed by the realization of Christ's appearance in history (not unique because it may happen to any person at any time after Christ's Advent).

The Chester *Shepherds' Play* (Play 7)

I give a more detailed account of the Chester *Shepherds' Play* than of those above so that the reader may see the correspondences to, as well as divergences from the Towneley ones, but I am particularly concerned to note those between the *Second Shepherds' Play* and the Chester *Shepherds*. The Chester play opens with a weary First Shepherd, Hankyn, who is solicitous of his sheep; he walks the world, he says, to find shelter to shield them from storms. More specifically, he is concerned to save them from

the scab or the rot or a cough with the numerous herbs he carries. For solace, Hankyn calls Harvey and the two yell for Tudd so that the three can eat together. The attempt to call Tudd and Tudd's entry intrude an anti-feminist note: Tudd is particularly anxious because he has dirtied one of his wife's pans (presumably from mixing his medicines). He concludes that men must obey their wives for fear of a 'clowte'. However, it is a mother, not a wife, one's 'dam,' not one's 'dame-keynn' who has the ability to attract Tudd when Hankyn and Harvey call him 'Tudd, Tibb's son,' for, they say, he loves his 'damys name'. This minor detail suggests that Tudd himself is a lamb in search of his dam, his mother (65-9).²⁵

Their feast takes place on a high hill (93-4). As the shepherds unpack their bags, they list an enormous amount of food, some local and some coming from a distance ('ale of Halton,' and 'jannock of Lancastershyre').²⁶ Only after their 'bellyes be full' (149) do they remember Trowle, the servant who keeps their flocks, and decide they should give him some of their left-overs ('bytlockes') and some leeks.

Garcus (Trowle) is the disgruntled servant (the other Shepherds call him a 'shrewe') though he too has medicines and he also is concerned for the sheep. Ostracised by the others and because of his lower status, he rages against all authorities: he has no regard for anyone, not even a king or duke (181-9); he curses the other Shepherds; and is determined to sit on his own hill by himself. He rejects the other Shepherds' food because, he says, the dirt on it is too deep and it has grubs. More important, he won't eat until he has his wages. As he rejects their food, he also says he will not join them because they do not keep good company; they are 'sitting without any songes' (205).

Trowle is finally tempted from his loneliness and anger when Tudd says they will wrestle after Trowle eats 'a morsell' with him. Trowle is ready for the match ('Nowe comes Trowle the Trewe') but still rejects their food and thereby antagonises them further. Trowle throws all three of them.²⁷ After defeating them, Trowle takes as his prize 'this curye, this clowt and this cake' (281-2). When the star appears the Shepherds are afraid (305, 350-52), yet they immediately reckon that it is a sign of immense import. They seem to be ready to follow it even though they have not been directed to do so as yet. They hear the *Gloria*, but are puzzled because they don't see a man near them (362). They analyse the song and argue about its words. Tudd thinks 'he,' the singer (like Mak), is a spy come to steal their sheep (394-5) — or else he is a shepherd ('a man of our craft'), for he is seemly (396-7). Trowle chimes in that he has come to change the

markings on their sheep (i.e. steal them by deceit): 'hee came by night — all thinges lefte — / our tuppes with tarre to teale' (398–9).

Our text then brings the Shepherds back to a discussion of the song, but the repetition probably signals there are alternate versions in the exemplar which later scribes merged.²⁸ Hankyn identifies the singer as Gabriel. Gladdened by the song they gradually reconstruct the correct phrases and words (420–35), as a consequence of which they agree that on their way to Bethlehem to sing a 'mery songe,' 'Here singe troly, loly, loly, loo', which would seem inappropriate.²⁹

The Angel (re-)appears (464) to tell them to go to Bethlehem where they will see the Christ Child. Their irreverent remarks about old Joseph (496–503) evoke responses from both Mary and Joseph who instruct them (and the audience) about the Immaculate Conception and that Joseph's marriage to Mary was without sin as a means of keeping her virginity and in order to protect her from shame and slander.³⁰ Joseph orders the Shepherds to go preach that they have seen their heavenly king. This is the moment when the Chester Shepherds are transformed into *pastores*. They 'Hail' the Child and report the prophecies before they offer their gifts: Hankyn gives a bell; Harvey a *flackett* ('flask') with a spoon; Tudd a cap; and Trowle his wife's old hose (an odd gift!). Then Four Boys, who have not been mentioned thus far offer their gifts: a bottle with a stopple; a hood; a pipe (a musical instrument); and a nuthook (for when Christ gathers fruit because Joseph will not be able to).

Harvey suggests they all go home singing, but then takes up Joseph's imperative; he says he will preach what Gabriel taught them, 'Singinge away hethen (*hence*) will I' (656). Tudd will go overseas to preach; he will no longer keep sheep. Trowle calls for amendment of sins and also forsakes shepherding to pray in an 'anker herby' (666).³¹ Hankyn will become a hermit to praise God and to pray while walking barefoot in the wilderness (669). He will reject the world and moan for his sins. Neither of the two religious types referred to by the Shepherds — itinerant preachers and anchorites/hermits — would have been appropriate after 1539.

It is clear that the Chester play existed in a simpler form at one time because there are stanza- and metre-changes and there are some fossil references. For example, at line 361 the shepherds say they have not seen anyone near them who had sung the *Gloria*, yet at line 405 the singer is referred to simply as Gabriel. Similarly, Harvey suggests the *three* of them leave singing. At the offering of gifts, Tudd says he will be the last of the three. The Four Boys were intruded into the text at some point as is

perhaps indicated by their absence from MS H. Lumiansky and Mills note that the Fourth Boy cannot be accommodated in the stanza that first introduces the three Boys, so the fourth may be an addition to balance the Fourth Shepherd, Trowle, even though Trowle, a servant, would not seem to need or even have had one.³² It appears that there was a play of the traditional three Shepherds to which (under the influence of Towneley?) the Trowle scenes were added. If we strip out the Trowle sections and the Four Boys, we get a relatively pious and modest representation of the Annunciation to the Shepherds similar to that at York. One may only wonder who came up with and inserted into the earlier play the disgruntled-servant plot.

THE RECEPTION OF THE CHESTER *SHEPHERDS' PLAY*

Images of the Shepherds and plays about them were as popular in the medieval and early-modern periods as they have been in the last hundred years. Although the *Quem quaeritis* was the most widely dispersed liturgical *representatio*, there were *Officia pastores* or similar tropes from the eleventh century onward.³³ The Chester *Shepherds' Play* remained popular for most people even beyond the suppression of the Whitsun cycle. The first notice of the play appears in a *Mayors List* for the year 1515–1516: ‘the shepards play & the Assumption of our lady was played in St Iohns churchyard’.³⁴ St John’s was the site for the Corpus Christi Play before it was moved to Whitsun and the main streets of the city.³⁵ Since the occasion was noted in a *Mayors List*, I think we can assume that the performances were special events. The last performance of the *Shepherds* was in October 1577 at the High Cross for the Earl of Derby and his retinue.³⁶ This late performance may have been a signal of gratitude for the Earl’s aid in evading the Archbishop of York’s inhibition against the 1572 performance but may also acknowledge the Derby’s ancient prerogative annually to license the minstrels (and whores) of Chester.³⁷ The *Shepherds* on their stilts continued to be part of the Midsummer Show through the later sixteenth century.³⁸

But not everyone was amused by the Whitson Plays. The Chester *Mayors Lists* record some discontent with the performances of 1572 and 1575.³⁹ One *List* says that the ‘Maier would needs haue the playes ... to goe forward, againste ye willes of ye Bishops of Canterbury Yorke & Chester’.⁴⁰ Another says that an ‘Inhibition’ was sent from the Archbishop (of York) but that it came too late. One simply remarks that the plays were played ‘thoughe manye of the Cittie were sore against the

settinge forthe therof'.⁴¹ There is more detail in the *Lists* under 1575.⁴² There are two complaints in these entries: some objected that the plays were played 'to the dislike of many' because the performance was only at one place in the city (rather than the usual four places) and others remarked that some of the plays were performed but others were not 'Iustified for the superstitions in theime'. But there was considerably more uproar than in 1572. Again, the Archbishop is said to have sent an Inhibition along with a letter from the Earl of Huntington, the Lord President of the Council of the North, for the attachment of Mayor John Savage on the same day the new Mayor, Henry Hardware, was elected because Sir John in contempt of the inhibition and letters had 'caused ye popish plaies of Chester to bee playd' the Sunday, Monday, Tuesday, and Wednesday after Midsummer (rather than over the usual three days).⁴³ As a consequence of this performance, John Savage and John Hankey, the mayor in 1572, were summoned before the Privy Council to answer for failing to obey the Inhibition. Presumably the charges were dropped, for after the hearing they returned to Chester.

These events are illuminated by David Mills' discovery of some letters and letter-books of Christopher Goodman, a noteworthy preacher and one of the translators of the Geneva Bible, vicar of Aldford (1570), and archdeacon of Richmond (1574).⁴⁴ His letters to the Earl of Huntingdon and the Archbishop of York relate a more complicated story than that the *Lists* describe, but the information in the *Lists* is essentially correct.

The most interesting item in the letters is Goodman's 'Notes of the absurdities &c in the Chester plays'.⁴⁵ Goodman's principal objections are either to actions without scriptural foundation or to what are referred to as superstitions.⁴⁶ Some of Goodman's objections are not surprising: the apocryphal midwives scene, for example. Of the *Shepherds Play* Goodman complains of:

The unreverent speaking of the shepherds who by the Scriptures
seem to be honest men
The foolish descanting of the Shepherds upon Gloria in excelsis.
The angels suspected of the Shepherds to be sheep-stealers. with a
lewd merry song.⁴⁷
Their kissing of the cratch & clothes.
Their vain offerings to move laughter & to maintain Superstition.
They forsake their vocation, not mentioned in Scripture
Some of the shepherds to have been an Anchorate or Eremite &c.

REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 147

Besides telling us what was objectionable to a Puritan divine, Goodman's complaint provides an intriguing possibility for dating the 'Late Banns' because the description of the *Shepherds' Play* appears to respond to his charge that the play is not scripturally based:

The appearinge Angell. & starr vpon Cristes birthe
The Shepperde poore of base and lowe degree
you Paynters and Glaseers. decke out with all myrthe
And see that Gloria. in excelsus. be songe merelye
ffewe wordes in the Pagiante. make merthe trulye
ffor all that the author had to stand vppon
Was glorie to god on highe & peace [t] on earthe to man

REED: Cheshire including Chester 1 336

The stanza is a bit contradictory. The end of the quatrain calls on the Painters and Glaziers to sing the *Gloria* 'merelye,' but the following line points out that the pageant doesn't make mirth that is true, because there is no scriptural foundation for most of the text. I suspect that the final three lines of the stanza above were added as a defence for the last performance in 1575.

Modern readers and playgoers seem fond of *Shepherds* plays, in part, I think, because playwrights were not constrained by the biblical text. Medieval producers of and audiences for *Shepherds* plays must have felt similarly despite the non-scriptural embellishments. We need only look at the traditions in painting and the other arts to see that the *Shepherds* in Bethlehem provided all kinds of opportunities to decide details of placement, physical appearance, clothing, the relationship of the appearance of the Angel(s) to the *Shepherds*, the *Shepherds'* (and Angels'?) presence at the manger, and other matters. But to some of the citizens of Chester and to Christopher Goodman the *Chester Shepherds' Play* went far beyond what the scriptures allowed. Consequently it and the characters in the play were suppressed.

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NOTES

1. Lawrence M. Clopper 'The Chester Plays at Toronto' *Research Opportunities in Renaissance Drama* 26 (1983) 109-16; and see Clopper 'The History and Development of the Chester Cycle' *Modern Philology* 75 (1978) 219-46, which, along with David Mills' additions, was partially incorporated into *REED*:

- Cheshire including Chester* edited Elizabeth Baldwin, Lawrence M. Clopper, and David Mills, 2 vols (Toronto UP, 2007) 2 886–97.
2. *The Towneley Plays* edited A.C. Cawley and Martin Stevens *EETS SS 13–14* (1994) 2 483.
 3. Malcom Parkes and Alexandra Johnston presented a paper at the Kalamazoo Congress in 2002, 'Huntington MS HM I as an Artifact: A Paleographical and Codicological Consideration', in which they argued for a date for the MS in the 1550s on the basis of a comparison of hands used in documents of the period. The paper has not yet appeared. Their conclusions were reported by Barbara Palmer in 'Recycling "The Wakefield Cycle": The Records' *Research Opportunities in Renaissance Drama* 42 (2002) 88–130, at 96. A. C. Cawley and Martin Stevens, with the aid of A. I. Doyle, dated the MS c. 1500 on the basis of handwriting but especially on the decorated initials of plays 1 and 2 and the strap-work capitals of 27 of the plays: *The Towneley Plays* 2 vols *EETS SS 13–14* (1994) 1 xv; and see their facsimile edition *The Towneley Cycle* (Leeds Texts and Monographs Medieval Drama Facsimiles 2; University of Leeds School of English, 1976) ix and xv–xvi, notes 2, 12, and 14.
 4. Lawrence M. Clopper *Drama Play and Game: English Festive Culture in the Medieval and Early Modern Period* (Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2001) 177–81.
 5. *The Chester Mystery Cycle* edited R. M. Lumiansky and David Mills, 2 vols *EETS SS 3 and 9* (1974, 1986) 2 103.
 6. I will use the Latin *pastores* to refer to the shepherds in their literate and prophetic guises.
 7. Luke is the only Gospel that recounts the story of the shepherds.
 8. This reference is made in the *Coventry Shearmen and Taylors' Play* and the *Towneley Second Shepherds' Play*.
 9. Writers of lyrics in the period used Mary's lack of knowledge to expound Christ's role in providential history; 'Stond wel, moder, ounder rode' is perhaps the best example: *English Lyrics of the XIIIth Century* edited Carleton Brown (Oxford UP, 1932) 87–9.
 10. The detail derives from Isaiah 1:3: 'An ox knows its owner and an ass the manger (Vulgate *praesepio*) of its lord; but Israel knows not me, and my people does not comprehend'; Joseph A. Fitzmeyer *The Gospel According to Luke* 2 vols. (The Anchor Bible; Garden City, New York: Doubleday, 1981) 1 394.
 11. *The York Plays, volume 1* edited Richard Beadle, *EETS SS 23* (2009) 101–105.
 12. And see lines 29–30. Gertrud Schiller says that the shepherds in the early Christian tradition are said to represent the church which emerged out of Jewry whereas the Magi represent the converted heathen part of mankind. See her *Iconography of Christian Art* translated Janet Seligman, 2 vols (London: Lund

Humphries, 1971–2) 1 60. And see Johannes de Caulibus (Pseudo-Bonaventure) *Meditations on the Life of Christ* translated Francis X. Taney Sr and others (University of North Carolina at Asheville: Pegasus Press, 2000) 33.

- 13 In *Piers Plowman* Conscience makes a similar point:

‘Ac to be conquerour called, þat comeþ of special grace ...
To make lordes of laddes of lond þat he wyneþ
And fre men foule þralles þat folwen no3t hise lawes.
The lewes þat were gentil men, Ies[u] þei despised,
Boþe his lore and his lawe; now are þei lowe cherles ...

B-Text 19: 30–35.

14. *The N-Town Play* edited Stephen Spector, 2 vols *EETS SS 11–12* (1991).
15. See W.O. Hassall *The Holkham Bible Picture Book* (London: Dropmore, 1954) where a shepherd tries to imitate the *Gloria* with *Glum glo ceo ne est rien. Allums la, nous la sauerums been* (fol. 13 and pages 89–90). In the illustration at the bottom of the page, two shepherds have as speech tags the *Gloria* and the *Te Deum*.
16. For lyrics addressed to and in praise of Mary, see, for example, John Lydgate’s ‘Hayle, glorious lady and hevenly queen’: *John Lydgate’s Minor Poems*, edited H.N. MacCracken *EETS ES 107* (1911) 280–2. For the connection to elevation prayers, see Pamela King *The York Mystery Cycle and the Worship of the City* (Cambridge: D. S. Brewer, 2006) 20–29.
17. *The Coventry Corpus Christi Plays* edited Pamela M. King and Clifford Davidson (EDAM Monograph Series 27; Kalamazoo: Medieval Institute Publications, Western Michigan University, 2000).
18. *Coventry Corpus Christi Plays* edited King and Davidson 169–73
19. The angel refers here to the shepherds’ fear (as indicated in Luke), but the latter are not afraid when they first hear the *Gloria* (250). And see Chester Play 7, line 465.
20. A.C. Cawley argued that the prodigious feast of the Shepherds is a mix of aristocratic and plebian fare; consequently he concluded the food was imaginary (‘The Grotesque Feast in the *Prima pastorum*’ *Speculum* 30 (1955) 213–17).
21. Compare Bernard of Clairvaux *Sermo* (IV) in *nativitate Domini* PL 183 cols 125–7; on-line at <www.binetti.ru/bernardus/38.shtml>; and *Piers Plowman* B Text 12:148–52.
22. The MS reads ‘shepardes’, which Cawley and Stevens emend to ‘husbandys’ for the rhyme.
23. E.g. *The York Plays* 5:161; *N.Town* 2:245; and a possible allusion in the Towneley *Noah* 3:383; and the Towneley *Second Shepherds Play* 13:223, 430.

- Piers is the Adam-figure in *Piers Plowman* B.6:25, 128; C.Pr.36, 8:24, 134; and see the reference to Genesis and the fallen Adam in 8:237–41. Chaucer's Plowman is said to be a *swynkere* (*General Prologue* 531, 536).
24. Lawrence J. Ross 'Symbol and Structure in the *Secunda Pastorum*' *Comparative Drama* 1 (1967–8) 122–43.
 25. Trowle later refers to 'we' shepherds as *sheep* (170).
 26. Although not every dish named in the play appears in the Painters' accounts, there is enough congruence to suggest that the food is real and plentiful; *REED: Cheshire including Chester* 122–4, 139–41, and 165–7.
 27. I think this incident, which appears in none of the other plays, is an allusion to wrestling which frequently occurred at spring festivals. English synods and councils routinely denounced wrestling in churchyards on feast days; see *Councils and Synods ... A. D. 1205–1313* edited F.M. Powicke and C. R. Cheney, 2 vols (Oxford UP, 1964) 1 35–36, 93, 709 and 2 1009. I suspect there were many young men ready to temporarily upend the hierarchy by throwing their elders.
 28. This long passage seems to be made up of alternate versions of the scene since there is repetition in the second half that is in a different stanza from the first. See *Chester Mystery Cycle* edited Lumiansky and Mills 2 118.
 29. See the note on line 447 + sd. One wonders what this song might be. MS H has the sd: *Tunc omnes pastores cum aliis adiuvantibus cantabunt hilare carmen*. Richard Rastall concludes that the *hilare carmen* is the 'merry song' of line 443; *Minstrels Playing: Music in Early English Religious Drama* 2 vols (Cambridge: D. S. Brewer, 2001) 2 254–5. Although the MSS do not agree on the reading, they do suggest the same kind of inappropriate song. Christopher Goodman, see above, calls this 'a lewd merry song'.
 30. This moment is treated differently in the other plays. In York Mary and Joseph are there but speak no lines; they are icons like those in paintings and other media. In Coventry Mary and Joseph are there but Mary speaks only four lines. The Towneley *Prima Pastorum* has Mary pray that her son will 'Rearde you this day' and that 'He graunt you for ay / His blys full euen / Contynuyng' (699–711), before directing them to 'Tell furth of this case' (709). In the Towneley *Second Shepherds' Play* Mary says that the Father of Heaven Omnipotent has sent his son to be conceived by her. To keep them from woe, she will pray for them (1063–75). In these plays Mary functions as *mediatrix*. The N.Town Joseph directs the shepherds to testify 'How God is born' (123). At the conclusion Mary has four lines in which she promises them a good end in heaven for their 'omage and 3oure syngyng'. Only in Chester and N.Town is there the order for them to preach or, in the case of N.Town, to testify. In the *Prima Pastorum* Mary functions primarily as *mediatrix* but she does tell them at the end to testify about what they have seen.

31. Ann K. Warren says there were three anchorholds in Chester in the fourteenth century, and a female anchorite in Cheshire in the sixteenth century until anchorites were put down along with other religious institutions at the Dissolution; *Anchorites and Their Patrons in Medieval England* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1985) 39, 202, 288.
32. *Chester Mystery Cycle* edited Lumiansky and Mills 2 120 note 607.
33. Karl Young *The Drama of the Medieval Church* 2 vols. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1933) 2 3–28.
34. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 67.
35. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 86.
36. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 xxxvii–xxxviii, 145, 1016. Christopher Goodman asserted that the Earl, the ‘chief of her Majesties commission for Cheshire & Lancashire’ and thus the local representative of the Council of the North headed by the Earl of Huntingdon (who had also received a letter from Goodman), abetted Mayor Hankey in ignoring the Archbishop’s inhibition and going forward with the performance.
37. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 lxx–lxxi.
38. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 36–44.
39. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 xxxvi–xxxix.
40. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 136–7.
41. In 1575 Andrew Tailer of the Dyers guild refused to pay his assessment towards the Whitsun plays and was detained; REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 171–2.
42. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 161–2.
43. The circumstances are a bit mystifying. If some of the plays were not performed and whatever was played was performed in one place, which would be more ‘efficient’, then why did the performance take four rather than three days? There is a stanza at the end of the *Balaam* (Play 5) that says the plays will continue the next day with the *Nativity of Christ*; *Chester Mystery Cycle* edited Lumiansky and Mills 1 97. Normally the first day would have ended after the *Adoration of the Magi* (Play 9).
44. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 143–8, 168–70.
45. REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 147.
46. The Rev. Robert Rogers, who signed one of the letters, shared Goodman’s dislike of the plays. At the end of his description of the Chester plays in the 1609 *Rogers Breviary*, he denounced them as an ‘Abomination of Desolation, with suche a Clowde of Ignorance’ that they defiled the scriptures; REED: *Cheshire including Chester* 1 345.
47. The extant Painters’ accounts list payment to only one Angel.